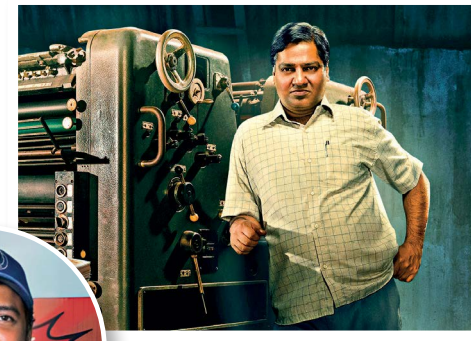




A SCANDALOUS SAGA
Gagan Dev Riar in *Scam 2003: The Telgi Story*; (inset) Tushar Hiranandani

ENTERTAINMENT

EVERYONE LOVES A GOOD SCAM

Scam 2003: The Telgi Story is a fictional retelling of the stamp paper scam powered by Gagan Dev Riar's pitch-perfect turn

"*Risk hai, toh ishq hai,*" said Pratik Gandhi as the infamous Harshad Mehta in the Hansal Mehta-directed and Applause-produced SonyLIV web series, *Scam 1992* (2020). Nearly three years later comes *Scam 2003: The Telgi Story*, and there's a new catchphrase: *"Daring toh karna padega, Darling."* It's voiced by Gagan Dev Riar, who plays Telgi, the mastermind behind the stamp paper scandal. *Scam 1992* was a gamechanger for both Gandhi and Mehta, with the latter becoming one of the most sought-after creators on OTT/streaming platforms. Riar and *Scam 2003* director Tushar Hiranandani wouldn't mind if the lightning—of audience love and critical praise—struck twice.

Hiranandani feels honoured to have the baton of the franchise passed to him. "*Scam* is such a big legacy, it's a big *jaaydad* [inheritance]," he says. "Hansal Sir said, 'Don't take any pressure, leave the pressure to me'." (Mehta is credited as the showrunner.) For Riar, best known for his work on stage in musicals like *Piya Behrupiya* and *Stories in a Song* and in Mira Nair's BBC One drama *A Suitable Boy* (2020), casting director Mukesh Chhabra's call to audition couldn't have come at a better time. With Covid-19 shutting down performance spaces for over a year, he was desperate for work. That the offer was to play a titular part in *Telgi* was the cherry on the cake. "You keep manifesting it [such opportunities]," he says. "But I am also lazy... *Ek time pe ek hi kaam karta hoon* [I do one project at a time]. Until I desperately need money, I won't go [for an audition]."

Scam 2003: The Telgi Story doesn't lionise the protagonist or vilify him. It paints him in shades of grey

Scam's appeal lay in how it humanised its anti-hero even as it recognised his acumen in finding and exploiting loopholes in the system. There's no lionising the protagonist, but even the vilification is kept under check. "I have to like him, I had to see him as a hero," says Riar of Telgi. "I played it from the point of view of where he thinks of himself as a modern-day Robin Hood. '*Maine bade logon se churaaya aur gareebon mein baant diya*' [I stole from the rich and distributed it among the poor]."

The first two episodes highlight Telgi's conviction that his business isn't illegal. They also show his curiosity, willingness to learn, confidence, ability to negotiate, and ambition. "*Chillar mein kaam kar rahe hain* [We are earning peanuts]," he tells his Gujarati partner. "*Paisa kamana nahin, banana hai* [I don't want to earn money, I want to make it]." For Riar, Telgi's ability to deceive is a marker of a sharp mind, one that enabled him to conceal his con for years. Telgi's downfall comes with an awareness of his wrongdoings. "He is grey like most of us," says Riar. It remains to be seen whether *Scam 2003* will repeat the success of its predecessor, but what it certainly establishes is that Gagan Dev Riar is an actor to watch out for. ■

Suhani Singh